Heal

By Carl Sasoon

The unnamed speaker is a shy, somewhat nervous man in his mid to late twenties. He is a scientific genetic botanist and tends to some plants while he speaks.

SPEAKER: The problem with Sterling Silvers is that they have a particular susceptibility to spotty blight. Peter Winslet bred Sterling Silver in 1971, claiming that, and I quote, "In the correct light, the silvery-white blooms of the rose take on a certain bluish cast..." Well, I don't know, but it ain't blue, it's just, well, silvery-white. Beautiful rose, but not blue. A blue rose, is of course, sort of the start of all of this, I suppose. You see, it was two weeks before Valentine's Day that I asked Sophie out to dinner for the first time, only to be challenged by her response of,

SOPHIE: *"You got it buddy, I'll see you there with a dozen baby blue roses."*

SPEAKER: And that night was a successful evening. I successfully spilled red wine all the way down my white shirt, and, I . . . uh . . . successfully won Sophie over with my apparent social grace and charm -- or lack thereof. I didn't have any blue roses to bring her that night, but she married me six months later. And, uh, I adored her. So, when the little boy who never really fit in grew up to become a genetic botanist who never really fit in . . . he, uh, he never expected that he would find his queen.

INTRODUCTION

He never expected a random act of violence would change the trajectory of his life. He never expected to live without her. He never expected to . . . . Heal by Carl Sasoon.

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SPEAKER: When you have everything you could possibly desire, why is it that your mind refuses to rest. Perhaps we all struggle with such . . . unease. Perhaps. There were times her blue eyes would flicker with . . . something . . . worry, restlessness . . . I wasn't certain. I'd awaken, hours before dawn, to find Sophie sitting at the edge of our bed . . . and as she was lost in her own thoughts, I would hold her and she would murmur,

SOPHIE: *"I've been worried about us, Babyluv."*

SPEAKER: There is no science to resolve the contortions of our psyches. And, so, I would hold her, and whisper quiet things, private things. Sing to her quietly as I held her, "*You are in my blood like holy wine. You taste so bitter, so bitter and so sweet. I could drink a case of you and I would still be on my feet. I would still be on my feet. . .*" *(link to music and lyrics at the end of this selection)* Sing to her until she slept and whatever demons or gods were tormenting her had fallen silent. I could not place this worry, and I could not fix it.

I have a temperature-controlled greenhouse, connected to the small lab, and, uh, that's where I was the night that my cell phone rang. It was deep into winter, when I answered the phone. And Sophie, spoke quickly, ***urgently***, I suppose would be the best way to describe it, she said,

SOPHIE: *"I will always be near to you, Babyluv. Close enough to touch"*

SPEAKER: . . . and the line was gone. Sophie didn't come home that night. I found myself downtown the next morning, speaking with a woman wearing a white lab coat and I was just on autopilot, an actor on a stage, improvising lines for a play I had not written. And in this play, this grand drama, this woman with kind and tired eyes took me to a room where the lights were very bright and the air was very cold this woman, she . . . showed me Sophie. And even though this was no longer a play it looked as if she were wearing stage makeup, because

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she had long, jagged slashes of red across her face where someone had cut her. Her blonde hair fanned out, matted in blood. Her body was covered with dark red. If this is difficult for you to hear, then perhaps imagine how it was for me to see. Because that was my life . . . my Queen on that table. And, umm, I could not fix her. I would have taken my Babyluv right away from there, taken her back to the lab and used anything, anything to breathe life back into that body, but it was impossible. There was no science to fix this. And so, instead, I leaned my face into Sophie's . . . *"I remember that time you told me, you said love is touching souls, surely you touched mine, cause part of you pours out of me in these lines from time to time . . ."* *(link to music and lyrics at the end of this selection)* I didn't want to leave Sophie alone there, she must have been so cold, but the woman led me away. I ask you, does worry manifest as premonitions? I don't know . . .

They did not have to look. The man, David Smith, turned himself in. I made a request to go down and speak with [him] and the request was granted. What I need to explain is that the bloodlust, the hunger that was inside of me was insatiable, and, so, I, uh, I did my research. There are things you can do, things you can bring in, that you can get past the elaborate systems of security. Even though I had never seen this man's face, I could envision the scenario in complete detail, the splattering of blood, the ending of his life.

In the weeks before I went to meet this man, Sophie began to visit me. I would see her, I would see her in the way that this man had left her, and often times I could not bear to look.

SOPHIE: *I don't know where to go, Babyluv.*

SPEAKER: I would reach out and I could not touch her.

SOPHIE: *I need you here with me.*

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SPEAKER: I could not bring her back.

SOPHIE: *I am so cold, Babyluv.*

SPEAKER: If there was a paradise, I could have found to be with her, I would have gone. *(Beat)* The day came for me to go, and I was prepared. And they led me into a small room with a table and two chairs, and in one of the chairs sat David Smith - and he was just so, so ordinary. Here in front me, this was the man who had murdered my wife, and in doing so, separated me from the land of the living. How many seconds did I have, if I wasn't fast enough I would fail. Not yet. Instead, I look directly into David Smith's eyes, brown pools and I ask him, "Why did you kill my wife?"

I don't believe David Smith blinked before he said, "I don't know. I think I needed to feel alive."

I sat very still, I did not move my eyes from his, "I loved my wife and you ended her life for no reason."

He dropped his gaze then, "I'm sorry. There's something wrong inside of me. Something I don't know how to fix." And then David Smith began to cry. *(Long Beat)*

We cannot fix something when we do not understand why it is broken. Or how it came to be. So I told this man, "I will try to forgive you, only because I will never forget my wife. My Sophie."

SOPHIE: *"I've been worried about us, Babyluv."*

SPEAKER: Sophie had visited almost every night in the days before I went to meet that man. And as sure as I stand here, she knew.

SOPHIE: *"You have to heal, my sweet, sweet boy."*

SPEAKER: I don't know how. I need to end this. I need you.

SOPHIE: *"You have me, always. Forever. And you know mercy in your heart. I don't want*

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to worry about us anymore. I don't want to worry about you, Babyluv Don't make me worry."

SPEAKER: And so, I could not. *(Beat – he returns to his roses)* I was worried that the blooms would be so fragile, but look at how strong they are. And how blue. As blue as the ocean, or lapis lazuli stones . . . or Sophie's eyes. Sophie's blue. It's taken me much, much longer than I would have planned to give her a dozen baby blue roses, but here they are, and I can only hope they are everything she would have wanted them to be. *(he begins to mix a concoction in beakers from his lab – a suicide cocktail – He contemplates drinking, but keeps stopping himself to talk)*

She still comes, you know, but not nearly as often, and her face now is as perfect and as clean as ever, and I know, for certain, is that there is a paradise, a beautiful place and that I will arrive there, when the time is determined, and I will be with my Sophie for eternity, and there will be no need for science of any sort and nothing will need fixing. *(he drinks from the beaker)* We will be surrounded by fields of blue roses -- every shade of blue the mind's eye has never even imagined. I see us dancing in groves of blue roses, bright, bright blue in the full bloom of sunlight.

SOPHIE: *I am not worried about us anymore, Babyluv.*

SPEAKER: I'm going to be there, Sophie, and I know you'll be waiting. *(He sings softly he re-unites with Sophie and they dance)* *"You're in my blood like holy wine, you taste so bitter and so sweet, I could drink a case of you darling, and I would still be on my feet. I would still be on my feet. Mmm. . . hmmm. . .*" (link to music and lyrics at the end of this selection) (He collapses to the floor a smile on his face)*

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2019 National Qualifier
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****Music and Lyrics to "A Case of You" by Joni Mitchell***
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=6voJjexENok

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